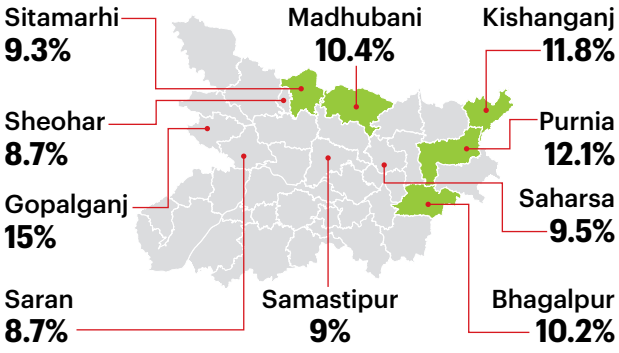
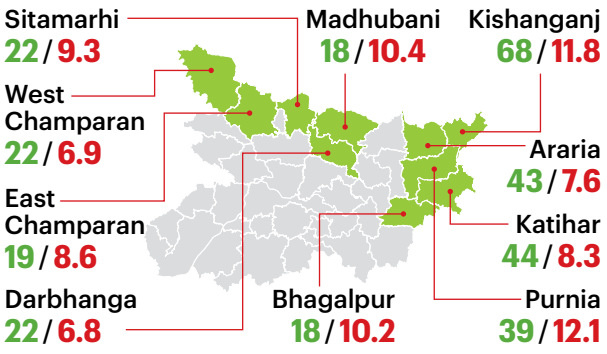
IS S.I.R. AN ANTI-MUSLIM EXERCISE?

Of the 10 districts with the highest deletions, five—Purnia, Kishanganj, Madhubani, Bhagalpur and Sitamarhi—have the biggest share of Muslims...

PERCENTAGE OF DELETED VOTERS



...but four of the 10 districts with the highest Muslim population also saw deletion rates lower than the state average of 8.3 per cent



Source: ECI, Census 2011 (comparison based on electoral roll released on Jan. 7, 2025 and draft roll released on Aug. 1, 2025)

Graphics by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

letion, their protests lack the ammunition needed to mount legal challenges or mobilise public opinion.

MYTHS AND PARALLELS

A persistent narrative surrounding the SIR is that it targets Muslim voters, particularly in the frontier districts where communal rhetoric often paints them as illegal Bangladeshi immigrants. The data presents a more nuanced picture. Among the 10 districts with the highest deletion rates, five—Purnia, Kishanganj, Madhubani, Bhagalpur and Sitamarhi—do have significant Muslim populations (see *Is SIR an Anti-Muslim Exercise?*). Yet, this correlation is muddied on closer scrutiny.

Kishanganj, Bihar's only Muslim-majority district (68 per cent of the population), did indeed see deletions of 11.8 per cent, higher than the state average of 8.3 per cent. But Katihar and Araria, with Muslim populations of 44 and 43 per cent, respectively, saw deletion rates of 8.27 per cent and 7.59 per cent, below the state average. Tellingly, Gopalganj district, which recorded the highest deletion rate at 15 per cent, does not have a particularly high Muslim population. Anyway, these variations suggest that while the overlap between Muslim concentration areas and high deletions warrants investigation, other factors like migration, documentation unavailability, or even administrative efficiency may be equally significant. "No direct correlation can be ascribed as yet," says poll analyst Amitabh Tiwari.



FALSE ALARM RJD's Tejashwi Yadav's presser in Patna after EC released the draft voters' list, Aug. 2

ANI

Another pattern shows how difficult it is to make out a narrative of targeted disenfranchisement. In 112 of Bihar's 243 assembly seats, voter deletions exceed the victory margins from the 2020 election, a statistic that suggests nearly half the state's constituencies could see their electoral outcomes altered by the revision exercise. But a deep dive shows that the NDA partners—BJP with 27 seats, Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) with 29 seats, and the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) with 1 seat—collectively hold 57 of these 112 vulnerable constituencies. This could mean the NDA's own MLAs are as exposed to the electoral impact of the SIR as their opponents. "Without a caste-wise breakdown, particularly on whether deletions are high among Muslims and Yadavs, it's impossible to determine if the BJP stands to gain from the exercise," says Tiwari.